preference. Its relationship with Russia has been qualitatively different from its ties with China. It is clearly not helpful for India if the two are perceived to be in the same basket. From time to time, efforts have been made to advance such an analysis and India, on its part, has refused to be drawn in. There has been no competitive element at all in its relationship with Russia. On the contrary, it is the continuous consideration that the two countries have extended to each other that has been the foundation of their partnership. Where China is concerned, it is a very different story, in part due to the unresolved boundary question. Therefore, India's geopolitical posture will not be amenable to the extrapolation of the Indo-Pacific into Europe, and it is essential that we get the West to understand this logic of strategy.

While countries are naturally impelled by their national interest, it is also true that this positioning can help to mitigate global frictions when the time comes. This has been already evident in the workings of the G20 and some other international platforms. Indeed, it could even be asserted that calming the global discourse and stabilizing the global economy is in itself a contribution to common good.

THE AFRICAN SOLIDARITY

When PM Modi announced at the New Delhi G20 Summit the membership of the AU in that body, it was a very special moment for India–Africa ties. A year before, he had made that commitment in Bali and, thereafter, took it up personally and seriously with other G20 leaders. To many African countries, it was natural that India should step forward and advance their cause.

Yet, the fact remains that the story of India–Africa relations is a relatively uncommented one. It is often forgotten that there is a really long history of contacts, whether fostered by the dhow or the caravan. The period of Western colonialism added its own texture, creating the beginnings of an Indian diaspora in that continent. The subsequent independence struggles have generated a unique solidarity that is still on display in global forums.

As with many other regions, what was a steady but unremarkable relationship got a quantum jump due to PM Modi's personal interest. Perhaps this also reflected the extensive contacts that his home state of Gujarat had with this region. A clear approach to cooperation with the